

# UNC Health

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill — Office of Innovation and Commercialization

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## Overview

UNC Health is a state entity and affiliated enterprise of the University of North Carolina system, operating as North Carolina's academic health system. It is headquartered in Chapel Hill and serves patients across all 100 North Carolina counties through a network of hospitals, clinics, and the clinical programs of the UNC School of Medicine. As a \$7.4 billion enterprise with 20 hospital campuses, more than 900 clinics, and approximately 56,000 employees, UNC Health is both the primary clinical platform of the UNC enterprise and the most direct institutional partner available to UNC researchers, the Office of Innovation and Commercialization, and external companies seeking to engage with a large, data-rich academic health system in the American Southeast.

**Internal Asset Note:** Unlike the external companies profiled in this series, UNC Health is not a partner to be approached from the outside — it is an internal partner whose capabilities, data infrastructure, clinical programs, and research ecosystem should be understood by the OIC as assets to be articulated when positioning UNC to industry.

*Sources: UNC Health [1]; Business North Carolina [2]; UNC Health Newsroom [3].*

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## Basic Organizational Information

|              |                                                                             |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Full Name    | UNC Health (University of North Carolina Health Care System)                |
| Headquarters | Chapel Hill, North Carolina, United States                                  |
| Website      | <a href="https://www.unchealth.org">https://www.unchealth.org</a>           |
| Newsroom     | <a href="https://news.unchealthcare.org">https://news.unchealthcare.org</a> |
| Org Type     | State Entity / Affiliated Enterprise of the UNC System                      |
| Revenue      | \$7.4 billion (Business North Carolina, 2026 — not audited)                 |
| Employees    | ~56,000                                                                     |
| Hospitals    | 17 hospitals, 20 hospital campuses                                          |

|              |                                                                                                                            |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clinics      | 900+                                                                                                                       |
| CEO          | Dr. Cristy Page (effective November 24, 2025; also Dean of UNC School of Medicine and Vice Chancellor for Medical Affairs) |
| EHR Platform | Epic (Epic@UNC, implemented ~2014)                                                                                         |

*Sources: Business North Carolina [2]; UNC Health Newsroom [3]; UNC Hospitals [4].*

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## System Scale and Structure

### Hospital Network

UNC Health comprises 17 hospitals and 20 hospital campuses. The system includes the flagship UNC Hospitals in Chapel Hill; UNC Health Rex and Rex Holly Springs in the Raleigh/Wake County area; UNC Health Blue Ridge in Morganton; UNC Health Rockingham in Eden; UNC Health Chatham in Siler City; UNC Health Lenoir in Kinston; UNC Health Onslow in Jacksonville; UNC Health Southeastern in Lumberton; and UNC Health Pardee in Hendersonville, among others. This statewide footprint extends clinical operations from the mountains to the coast, covering both urban academic medical centers and rural critical access hospitals across all 100 North Carolina counties.

### Academic Medical Center — UNC Hospitals, Chapel Hill

- North Carolina Cancer Hospital (clinical base of UNC Lineberger Comprehensive Cancer Center)
- North Carolina Children's Hospital
- North Carolina Memorial Hospital
- North Carolina Neurosciences Hospital
- North Carolina Women's Hospital
- UNC Health Hillsborough Campus

UNC Hospitals employs more than 7,100 people at the Chapel Hill campus, including 1,100 medical staff and 780 resident physicians. Over 800,000 people are cared for at UNC practices and clinics each year.

*Sources: Business North Carolina [2]; UNC Health Newsroom [3]; UNC Hospitals [4]; US News [5].*

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## Quality, Rankings, and Accreditation

### US News Best Hospitals 2025–26

- No. 2 hospital in North Carolina and No. 2 in the Triangle region (US News 2025–26, released July 29, 2025).
- Four nationally ranked adult specialties: cancer (No. 48), ear nose and throat (No. 44), urology (No. 31), and rehabilitation (No. 46).
- High performing in five adult specialties and 14 common adult procedures and conditions, including COPD, colon cancer surgery, diabetes, and heart failure.
- Nationally ranked in eight pediatric specialties.

- UNC Health Rex: No. 4 in North Carolina, No. 3 in the Triangle; high-performing in gastroenterology and GI surgery.

### Magnet Nursing Designation

UNC Hospitals has attained Magnet designation from the American Nurses Credentialing Center for the fourth time — a recognition earned by fewer than 10% of hospitals nationwide and widely cited as the highest national honor in nursing.

*Sources: UNC Health Newsroom [5]; CBS17 [8]; Business North Carolina [2].*

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## Research Infrastructure

### NIH and External Research Funding

**Research Scale (July 2024–June 2025):** UNC School of Medicine research funding totaled more than \$641 million, including \$345 million from the NIH. Across UNC-Chapel Hill, 250 faculty experts are leading more than 500 AI and machine learning projects, totaling \$163 million in research awards in the five years prior to mid-2025.

### NC TraCS Institute

The North Carolina Translational and Clinical Sciences Institute (NC TraCS) is UNC's NIH-funded Clinical and Translational Science Award (CTSA) hub, receiving funding from the NIH, UNC Health, the State of North Carolina, UNC Lineberger, the UNC School of Medicine, and the UNC Office of the Vice Chancellor for Research & Economic Development. NC TraCS provides translational science infrastructure across the research enterprise and co-led the development of SHIRE.

### UNC Lineberger Comprehensive Cancer Center

- One of only 49 NCI-designated Comprehensive Cancer Centers in the United States and the only public NCI-designated Comprehensive Cancer Center in North Carolina.
- Received an “exceptional” rating — the highest category — in its most recent NCI review.
- 325 members drawn from more than 40 departments across UNC.
- 200-plus clinical trials across all phases of investigation.
- \$28 million ARPA-H award in 2025 for the EVOLVE trial for metastatic breast cancer — a biomarker-driven adaptive treatment trial modifying plans in near real-time.
- 2024: Launched hybrid decentralized clinical trials bringing cancer trials to rural patients across North Carolina, with two trials enrolling and 20 in development.

*Sources: UNC Research [9]; NC TraCS [10][11]; NCI [12]; Chapelboro [13]; UNC-Chapel Hill [14].*

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## Digital and AI Infrastructure

### SHIRE — Secure Health Informatics Research Environment

The single most significant recent development in UNC Health's research infrastructure is SHIRE, the Secure Health Informatics Research Environment. SHIRE was jointly built by UNC-Chapel Hill, the UNC School of Medicine, NC TraCS, and UNC Health, and was publicly announced by Chancellor Lee H. Roberts and UNC Health CEO Dr. Cristy Page on April 8, 2026.

**SHIRE:** A HIPAA-compliant, secure, cloud-based analytics platform enabling credentialed researchers to develop and test advanced AI models using EHR data from UNC Health. Supports large-scale clinical dataset modeling with rigorous privacy safeguards, local LLMs deployed behind secure firewalls, multimodal data integration (imaging, genomics, clinical notes), and a structured IRB-governed data access review process. Went live November 3, 2025. Full transition from prior CDW-H system expected by end of 2026. Early research targets: precision oncology, rare disease, mental health.

The launch of SHIRE opens documented opportunities for technology companies, life sciences organizations, and health AI developers to partner with UNC on AI-enabled solutions using real-world clinical data within a shared governance framework.

### **Epic@UNC — EHR Platform and AI Co-Development**

UNC Health operates on Epic as its enterprise EHR (~2014 implementation) and has served as a documented early-adoption and co-development site for several of Epic's highest-priority AI initiatives:

- **Generative AI patient message drafting (2023):** UNC Health was selected by Epic as one of the first health systems in the country to pilot generative AI tools for auto-drafting clinician responses to patient messages. Initial rollout began with five to ten physicians.
- **Nuance DAX Copilot expansion (2024):** UNC Health expanded deployment of Nuance Dragon Ambient eXperience Copilot — Microsoft's ambient clinical documentation AI embedded in Epic — to more providers system-wide. UNC Health was among 150 health systems globally deploying the tool at scale.
- **Rare disease coding tool launch (February 2026):** UNC Health launched the world's first standardized rare-disease coding tool, integrating Mondo Disease Ontology codes into Epic across 20 hospitals and 900-plus clinics.

### **Ambient Clinical AI — Abridge (2025)**

In 2025, UNC Health implemented Abridge, an ambient clinical documentation AI, as part of Abridge's broader rollout across 100-plus health systems. UNC Health was named alongside Duke Health, Johns Hopkins, Mayo Clinic, and Memorial Sloan Kettering as a 2025 implementation site. Abridge raised a \$250 million Series D tied to that milestone. UNC Health Southeastern also deployed ambient AI across approximately 60 providers in orthopedics, emergency services, primary care, and oncology.

*Sources: UNC-Chapel Hill [15]; NC TraCS [11]; UNC Research [9]; DistillINFO [16]; Becker's [17]; Fierce Healthcare [18][19]; Becker's [20]; Medical Economics [21]; UNC Health Southeastern [22].*

## **Strategic Themes**

- \$7.4 billion enterprise across 17 hospitals and 900-plus clinics serving all 100 North Carolina counties.

- New CEO Dr. Cristy Page (November 2025) — primary care and rural health expert — with explicit focus on innovation, AI, and broadening access across NC.
  - SHIRE as shared AI research infrastructure enabling external partners to engage with UNC Health clinical data under structured governance, launched April 2026.
  - Epic-embedded AI co-development history: documented early-adoption of Epic generative AI (2023), Nuance DAX Copilot (2024), and rare disease coding tool (February 2026).
  - Lineberger NCI Comprehensive Cancer Center status, ARPA-H funding, and decentralized trial innovation positioning UNC as a translational oncology research hub.
  - NC TraCS as the translational science backbone connecting basic research, clinical investigation, and implementation.
  - Gillings School's new Center for Artificial Intelligence and Public Health (CAIPH) expanding the AI-in-health footprint into population health informatics.
  - \$641 million in School of Medicine research funding (July 2024–June 2025), including \$345 million from NIH.
  - Abridge, DAX Copilot, and Epic generative AI adoption signaling active AI integration rather than passive evaluation.
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## Positioning for External Partnership Discussions

### What UNC Health Offers External Partners

- **Real-world clinical data at scale:** SHIRE enables external partners to engage with UNC Health EHR data under a responsible AI framework and structured governance.
- **Validated clinical environment:** UNC Health's early-adoption role for Epic AI, Abridge, and Nuance DAX Copilot establishes it as a health system capable of testing, deploying, and evaluating novel AI tools in live care delivery settings.
- **Translational research infrastructure:** NC TraCS, Lineberger, and the UNC School of Medicine provide the regulatory, clinical trial, and sponsored research infrastructure for external companies to design and execute studies at UNC Health.
- **Rural health reach:** Statewide footprint from urban academic medical centers to rural critical access hospitals, relevant to partners with documented rural health priorities and to federal funding opportunities targeting underserved populations.
- **Rare disease and precision medicine:** The Mondo Disease Ontology launch, Lineberger's NCI designation, and the ARPA-H EVOLVE trial establish validated infrastructure for complex, data-driven clinical work.

### Partnership Framing by Company

- **For Apple:** UNC Health's digital health adoption, ambulatory clinic scale, and patient-facing MyChart infrastructure create alignment with Apple's ResearchKit model, wearable health data research, and decentralized study designs.

- **For Google:** Statewide rural presence, NC TraCS infrastructure, and Gillings population health research capacity align with Google's documented investment in clinician education and rural health transformation.
  - **For Microsoft:** The Nuance DAX Copilot deployment at UNC Health is already a documented partnership; SHIRE's cloud infrastructure creates additional Azure and data science collaboration opportunities.
  - **For Epic:** The UNC Health–Epic relationship is the most operationally embedded of any company in this profile series, with documented co-development across generative AI, ambient documentation, interoperability, and rare disease coding — making UNC Health a reference site for Epic's Cosmos AI program.
  - **For Johnson & Johnson:** UNC Health's translational medicine, clinical trial infrastructure through NC TraCS and Lineberger, and MedTech evaluation capabilities create alignment with J&J's Innovative Medicine and MedTech segments.
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## Risk and Caution Notes

- Do not cite the \$7.4 billion revenue figure as audited; it is reported by Business North Carolina (2026) and has not been independently verified against UNC Health's official audited financial statements.
  - UNC Health is a state entity subject to North Carolina governance requirements; partnership structures involving IP licensing, data sharing, or sponsored research must account for state governance and UNC System policies.
  - Dr. Cristy Page became CEO in November 2025; strategy and key relationships under new leadership are still establishing their public record. Confirm current leadership positions before using in formal outreach.
  - SHIRE went live November 2025 and is still transitioning from the prior CDW-H system; characterize it as operational but maturing, with full transition expected by end of 2026.
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## Expected Report Angle and Positioning

**Positioning Summary:** UNC Health should be framed as (1) North Carolina's academic health system — a \$7.4 billion state enterprise with 17 hospitals, 900-plus clinics, and 56,000 employees serving all 100 counties; (2) a research-enabled clinical platform anchored by NC TraCS, UNC Lineberger (NCI Comprehensive Cancer Center), and \$641 million in annual research funding; (3) the owner and operator of SHIRE — a cloud-based AI research environment launched April 2026 — the most direct mechanism for external partners to engage with UNC Health's real-world clinical data under responsible governance; (4) an active, documented early-adoption site for Epic generative AI, Nuance DAX Copilot, Abridge, and the world's first Epic-integrated rare disease coding system; and (5) a system undergoing leadership transition under CEO Dr. Cristy Page, with an explicit orientation toward AI, rural health innovation, and broadening partnership and commercialization relationships across North Carolina.

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